

## Evaluating Theological Education in The Apostolic Church Nigeria: Contributions, Challenges and Future Directions

Caleb Abiodun Adeleye, PhD <sup>1</sup>; Oluwasegun Peter Aluko, PhD <sup>2</sup>; Saibu A. Owoeye, PhD<sup>2</sup>; Emmanuel Olurokan Olowoyeye, PhD<sup>3</sup>

<sup>1</sup>Department of Religious Studies, Faculty of Arts, National Open University of Nigeria Osogbo Study Centre, Nigeria. <sup>2</sup>Department of Religious Studies, Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife, Nigeria. <sup>3</sup>Department of Religious Studies, Gombe State University, Gombe, Nigeria.

Corresponding author: [adeleyecalebabiodun@gmail.com](mailto:adeleyecalebabiodun@gmail.com)

DOI: <https://doi.org/10.62154/qjrt.2024.02.010408>

### Abstract

This study examines the contributions and challenges of theological education within The Apostolic Church Nigeria (TACN) from its establishment in 1931 to the present. The objectives are to explore the historical development of TACN's theological institutions, assess their impact on doctrinal teaching and ministerial effectiveness, and identify the challenges in sustaining these educational programmes. Employing a historical and qualitative research methodology, the study utilises document analysis, interviews with key stakeholders – including faculty, alumni, and current students – and thematic analysis to gather insights into the evolving landscape of theological education in TACN. The findings reveal that TACN's commitment to theological education has significantly enhanced its leaders' intellectual and spiritual capacities, contributing to the church's doctrinal consistency and overall growth. Institutions such as The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary in Amumara and The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary in Jos have structured ministerial training. However, challenges such as limited financial resources, cultural resistance to formal education, and the need to balance spiritual empowerment with academic rigour persist. The study concludes that for TACN to continue advancing its theological education programmes, it must invest strategically in infrastructure, technology, and faculty development while contextualising theological training to meet contemporary needs. The recommendations emphasise fostering a holistic approach integrating academic rigour with spiritual formation. This study contributes to understanding TACN's educational framework and offers practical insights for enhancing theological education within other Pentecostal movements facing similar challenges.

**Keywords:** Theological Education, The Apostolic Church Nigeria, Ministerial Training, Doctrinal Teaching, Theological Seminaries.

### Introduction

The Apostolic Church Nigeria (TACN) has been a significant force within Nigeria's Christian landscape since its formal establishment in 1931. Throughout its history, TACN has played a crucial role in Nigeria's spiritual, social, and educational development (Worsfold, 1991). A cornerstone of the church's influence has been its unwavering commitment to theological

education, aimed at nurturing both the intellectual and spiritual capacities of its leaders. Through the establishment of numerous seminaries and colleges, TACN has ensured doctrinal fidelity and pastoral excellence by training pastors, evangelists, and church officials across Nigeria and beyond.

Theological education in Nigeria traces its roots to early missionary activities, which focused on preparing indigenous clergy for leadership roles within the church (Fafunwa, 1974; Sanneh, 1983). Initially, Pentecostal churches like TACN were sceptical of formal theological education, favouring direct spiritual empowerment and divine calling over academic training (Kalu, 2008). However, as the church grew, it recognised the necessity of structured theological education to ensure doctrinal soundness and ministerial effectiveness. This marked a shift in the church's approach, as theological institutions became essential to equipping church leaders for the complexities of contemporary ministry.

TACN's commitment to theological education is evident in the establishment of key institutions such as The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary in Amumara, The Apostolic Church Bible College and Seminary in Calabar, and The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary in Jos, among others. These institutions offer programmes designed to provide comprehensive training in theology, pastoral care, and leadership, ensuring that TACN's ministers are well-prepared for both the spiritual and practical demands of ministry. Despite these strides, TACN has faced challenges in advancing theological education. Cultural resistance to formal education was a significant barrier in the early years, with some Pentecostal contexts viewing academic training as secondary to spiritual empowerment and divine experience. Additionally, resource constraints have limited the ability of these institutions to expand, affecting both the quality of education and the recruitment of qualified faculty. Furthermore, Pentecostalism's emphasis on experiential spirituality, particularly gifts of the Spirit such as healing, prophecy, and speaking in tongues, often led to ambivalence toward formal theological training (Anderson, 2004; Kalu, 2008). Nevertheless, TACN has made significant progress in balancing spiritual empowerment with academic training, emphasising the importance of both in developing effective church leadership.

### **Problem Statement and Objectives**

However, significant challenges remain in advancing and sustaining TACN's theological education programmes. One key issue is the ongoing tension within Pentecostal communities between spiritual experiences and formal academic training. Many within TACN have historically preferred direct divine calling and spiritual empowerment over structured theological education, which has hindered the widespread acceptance of formal training. This ambivalence, especially in contexts where charismatic gifts like prophecy and healing are highly valued, continues to affect the church's ability to promote theological education as essential to ministerial effectiveness.

In addition, TACN's theological institutions face substantial resource constraints that limit their capacity for growth. The lack of adequate funding restricts the ability to expand programmes, improve infrastructure, and recruit highly qualified faculty. This financial limitation compromises the quality of theological education, which impacts future church leaders' intellectual and spiritual development. If not addressed, these challenges threaten the long-term sustainability of TACN's mission to equip well-rounded, doctrinally sound, and spiritually empowered ministers.

Addressing these problems is crucial for ensuring that TACN can continue providing effective ministerial training that balances academic rigour and spiritual depth. This study explores these issues, assesses their impact on the church's mission, and proposes strategies to strengthen and sustain TACN's theological education programmes.

This paper is structured as follows: First, it provides a historical overview of theological education within TACN, detailing the founding of key seminaries. Second, it evaluates the contributions of these institutions to TACN's mission, focusing on their role in shaping doctrinal teaching and ministerial effectiveness. Finally, it discusses the challenges faced by TACN in sustaining its theological education programmes and suggests strategies for enhancing their effectiveness.

### **Conceptual Framework for Pentecostal Theological Education**

Pentecostal theological education has evolved significantly since the early 20th century, reflecting the dynamic and diverse nature of the Pentecostal movement. This mode of education aims to equip individuals for ministry and deepen their understanding of Pentecostal theology, spirituality, and practice. In the world over, Pentecostal theological education began with a focus on practical ministry training rather than formal academic study. Early Pentecostals were often sceptical of higher education, fearing it might lead to a loss of spiritual fervour (Frestadius, 2021). However, as the movement's need for structured theological education became apparent, Bible schools and training institutes were established to provide foundational biblical and theological knowledge on spiritual formation and practical ministry skills (Topf, 2021). This conceptual framework combines key elements that define Pentecostal theological training: spiritual empowerment, academic rigour, mission-oriented training, and contextualised theology. These components reflect the unique characteristics of Pentecostalism, particularly its emphasis on the active role of the Holy Spirit in ministry, and the need for practical, mission-driven leadership in a diverse and global context.

### **Spiritual Empowerment**

At the heart of Pentecostal theological education is the belief in spiritual empowerment, which emphasises the direct and ongoing influence of the Holy Spirit in shaping ministers for effective service (Knoetze, 2022). Pentecostals view the Holy Spirit as essential for personal transformation, ministry effectiveness, and congregational leadership (Kgatle,

2024). Consequently, theological education in Pentecostal settings incorporates not only academic study but also practices that foster spiritual growth, such as prayer, fasting, prophecy, and other charismatic experiences. Spiritual empowerment is seen as foundational for preparing ministers to lead vibrant, Spirit-filled congregations (Anderson, 2004). Recent scholarship emphasises the role of experiential spirituality in Pentecostal education, underscoring how spiritual formation must go hand-in-hand with theological training to cultivate leaders who are sensitive to the Spirit's guidance (Cartledge & Swoboda, 2016).

### **Academic Rigour**

While Pentecostalism historically emphasised spiritual experience over formal education (see Dayton, 1987; Cox, 1995; Alvarez, 2000), contemporary Pentecostal theological institutions increasingly recognise the importance of academic rigour (Quampah & Naidoo, 2000). These institutions now focus on providing in-depth biblical and theological knowledge, aiming to produce leaders who are Spirit-filled and intellectually equipped to handle complex theological and pastoral issues (Whitt, 2013; Aryeh, 2018). Academic training in exegesis, hermeneutics, and doctrinal theology ensures that Pentecostal ministers can maintain doctrinal integrity while engaging with contemporary social and theological debates (Castelo, 2015). By integrating academic rigour with spiritual formation, Pentecostal theological education helps develop leaders capable of navigating the challenges of modern ministry while remaining grounded in Pentecostal distinctive (Yong, 2010).

### **Mission-Oriented Training**

Pentecostalism is inherently mission-oriented, and this focus is reflected in its theological education programmes (Ott, 2001). Pentecostal institutions prioritise the development of practical ministry skills, such as preaching, church planting, and evangelism, aligning with the movement's emphasis on spreading the gospel and fulfilling the Great Commission (Akanbi & Beyers, 2017). Students are trained not only in theology but also in leadership, pastoral care, and cross-cultural ministry, preparing them for both local and global mission work. This mission-driven approach is essential to the Pentecostal worldview, which views every believer as a potential minister called to actively participate in advancing the kingdom of God (Quampah & Naidoo, 2000; Awojobi, 2020). The training provided in Pentecostal seminaries equips leaders to engage in dynamic, Spirit-led ministry that addresses both spiritual and practical needs within diverse communities (Nguyen, 2008).

### **Contextualisation of Theology**

Pentecostal theological education recognises the need for contextualised theology, which adapts theological training to the unique social, cultural, and religious contexts of different regions (Nguyen, 2008). As Pentecostalism continues to grow globally, particularly in the Global South, the need for context-specific theological education becomes more urgent

(Kgatle, 2018). Pentecostal seminaries are increasingly addressing local issues, such as indigenous spiritualities, social justice, and community-based approaches to evangelism, ensuring that their theological frameworks remain relevant to the cultures in which they minister (Kgatle, 2018). For example, in African contexts, Pentecostal theological education often engages with African traditional religions, offering a contextualised theology that speaks directly to local spiritual and social realities (Asamoah-Gyadu, 2005). By embracing contextualisation, Pentecostal institutions ensure that their theology is not abstract or disconnected from the lived experiences of their congregations (Gathogo, 2022).

### **Balancing Spiritual Empowerment and Academic Rigour**

A critical aspect of Pentecostal theological education is balancing spiritual empowerment with academic rigour. Historically, Pentecostals viewed formal education with suspicion, fearing it could undermine reliance on the Holy Spirit (Banda, 2019). However, as Pentecostalism has matured, theological institutions have sought to integrate both spiritual formation and academic study, recognising that effective ministry requires a combination of spiritual sensitivity and theological competence (Feller & Lombaard, 2018). This balance is reflected in curricula that include both academic coursework and opportunities for personal spiritual development, such as worship services, retreats, and mentorship programmes. Integrating these two elements ensures that Pentecostal leaders are Spirit-led and intellectually equipped to engage with theological, social, and cultural challenges in their ministry (Quampah & Naidoo, 2000; O'Brien, 2019).

### **Institutional Support and Global Networks**

The global nature of Pentecostalism has given rise to international networks and partnerships that support theological education (Deininger, 2013; Miller, 2013). These networks provide resources, facilitate faculty exchanges, and foster collaboration between Pentecostal institutions across different regions (Deininger, 2013). For example, institutions like the Pentecostal Theological Seminary in the United States of America and the Pentecostal Theological College in Africa collaborate through global partnerships to enhance theological education standards and share best practices (de Beer, 2020; Anderson, 2004). These connections allow Pentecostal institutions to address challenges such as limited resources and faculty shortages while promoting ecumenical dialogue with other Christian traditions. By fostering international collaboration, Pentecostal theological education continues to grow in its ability to produce competent leaders for the global church (Nel, 2018).

### **Theoretical Underpinnings**

Several theoretical frameworks undergird Pentecostal theological education. Experiential theology, as articulated by John Wesley, emphasises the importance of lived spiritual experience in shaping theological understanding. This aligns with Pentecostalism's focus

on the Holy Spirit's active role in ministry and life (Dayton, 1987). Additionally, charismatic theology emphasises the gifts of the Spirit, as explored by theologians like Simon Chan, and underscores the importance of maintaining a charismatic focus in theological education. Finally, contextual theology, as developed by scholars like Robert Schreiter, highlights the need for theology that is culturally relevant and grounded in local contexts, a key concern for Pentecostal institutions operating in diverse regions (Schreiter, 1985).

### Methodology

This study employs a historical and qualitative research methodology to explore the theological education's development, contributions, and challenges within TACN. A historical approach was used to trace the evolution of theological education in TACN from 1931 to the present. Primary and secondary sources, including church records, archival materials, and publications were analysed to understand the church's early resistance and gradual embrace of formal theological education. Also, semi-structured interviews were conducted with faculty, alumni, and current students from TACN's theological institutions. These interviews provided insights into the impact of theological education on ministerial effectiveness and doctrinal teaching, as well as the challenges faced by the institutions. Thematic analysis was used to identify key patterns from the data. Church reports, seminary publications, and institutional documents were reviewed to assess enrolment trends, programme offerings, and institutional challenges, providing a comprehensive view of TACN's theological education framework. Informed consent was obtained from all interview participants, and confidentiality was ensured by anonymising data. The study adhered to ethical standards in collecting and storing information.

### Historical Development of Theological Education in Nigeria

In Nigeria, the development of theological education can be traced back to early missionary efforts, to train indigenous clergy to support the missionary agenda. Scholars such as Fafunwa (1974) and Sanneh (1983) emphasise that early theological institutions were vital in transferring ecclesiastical authority to local leadership, which was essential for the sustainability of Christianity in the country. While these early missionary efforts laid the groundwork for theological education, they were mainly directed toward mainline denominations.

For Pentecostal churches like TACN, however, the journey toward embracing formal theological education has been more complex. Initially, Pentecostals, including TACN, were sceptical of academic training, preferring spiritual empowerment and divine calling over structured education (Kalu, 2008). This sentiment is echoed by Anderson (2004), who notes that Pentecostalism's emphasis on experiential spirituality often led to resistance toward theological formalism. While this perspective helped Pentecostals prioritise spiritual authenticity, it also delayed the development of formal educational structures within churches like TACN.

The shift in TACN's stance towards theological education is documented by Worsfold (1991), who highlights how the church's expansion led to the realisation that formal training was essential for doctrinal integrity and pastoral effectiveness. This transition allowed TACN to align with broader educational movements within Christianity while maintaining its Pentecostal distinctives. As a result, TACN began establishing seminaries and Bible colleges to train its leaders formally, addressing the challenges of sustaining doctrinal consistency across a rapidly growing denomination.

Theological education plays a pivotal role in shaping church leadership, particularly in Pentecostal settings where leadership often emerges through spiritual charisma. Formal theological education has significantly contributed to leaders' intellectual and spiritual growth (Knoetze, 2022). It ensures that ministers are spiritually equipped intellectually and grounded in biblical interpretation, pastoral care, and leadership strategies.

Kalu (2008) notes that the balance between spiritual empowerment and academic training has been a recurring theme in a broader Pentecostal context. Pentecostal leaders trained in theological institutions are often better positioned to lead their congregations through the complexities of modern ministry, such as social change, doctrinal challenges, and interfaith dialogue. The impact of formal theological education is also seen in its role in shaping doctrinal fidelity, a point reinforced by Anderson (2004), who argues that structured theological training helps maintain doctrinal consistency in large, growing denominations. However, there is ongoing tension within Pentecostal communities, including TACN, between experiential spirituality and the perceived rigidity of formal theological training. Some argue that academic education could stifle spiritual spontaneity, which has historically been a defining feature of Pentecostalism (Ukah, 2008). This tension highlights the challenge of integrating formal education with the charismatic aspects of Pentecostal leadership.

### **A Historical Overview of Theological Education within TACN: The Founding of Key Seminaries**

Before going into the founding of key seminaries of the TACN, it would be good first to give a succinct overview of the antecedent to the founding of theological institutions in the church. Also, it is noteworthy to discuss the apprenticeship mode (in-service training) and the inception of theological training in the church.

#### **Antecedent to the Founding of Theological Institutions in TACN**

At the inception of The Apostolic Church in Nigeria (TACN) in 1931, theological education was largely informal, with a significant portion of indigenous ministers being illiterate farmers, artisans, and traders. Apart from European missionaries, only a few leaders like Pastors D. O. Odubanjo, S. G. Adegboyega, and J. A. Babatope had any formal education. Babatope was the only trained Anglican catechist among them. This educational gap led to the development of various forms of ministerial training in TACN, including the

apprenticeship model, Sunday school, and eventually formal theological institutions (Worsfold, 1991:262).

While apprenticeship and Sunday school offered semi-formal education, theological institutions and religious departments in secular institutions eventually became the primary means for formal theological education in TACN. This was crucial for the church's life and mission, as theological education ensured that ministers could lead worship and interpret biblical texts in a meaningful way. Historically, the Church had developed schools for lay and clergy teachers, organising catechetical systems that provided basic theological education to baptismal candidates. Over time, however, theological education became more associated with clergy and church professionals, often lacking focus and direction in many parts of the global Christian community, including TACN.

In Nigeria, and particularly among Pentecostals, there has been resistance to formal theological education. According to Dada (2007:41), three factors contribute to this aversion: first, the belief that a calling into ministry only requires spiritual direction from the Holy Spirit, often mediated through prayer, fasting, and spiritual exercises; second, the concern that theological education fosters pride and arrogance; and third, the fear that it could lead people astray from the faith. These beliefs led to a perception that theological education was unnecessary, especially in the early days of TACN. Education, in general, was seen by some as antithetical to spirituality, which prompted reliance on informal modes of training such as in-service or apprenticeship methods (Interview with Awotanmi, 2012).

Thus, while theological education is recognised as vital for church growth and leadership, early resistance within TACN mirrored broader Pentecostal concerns about its necessity. However, over time, theological institutions were established to meet the growing need for well-trained ministers capable of both spiritual and intellectual leadership.

### **Apprenticeship Mode (In-Service Training)**

In the early days of TACN, the apprenticeship mode, or in-service training, played a critical role in the development of church leaders. Ministers who claimed to have received a divine calling were typically put on probation and placed under the mentorship of experienced, often elderly ministers. These senior ministers acted as guardians, guiding the less experienced ministers in their pastoral journey. This form of ministerial development was a key feature of the church's early approach to leadership training.

One of the prominent leaders developed through this system was Pastor I. G. Sakpo, who began his ministerial career as a helper under Pastors Esinsinade and D. O. Odubanjo. In 1931, Pastor J. B. Esinsinade, a national leader of the church, took Sakpo into the Mission House at 24 Abasi Street, Ijebu-Ode, where Sakpo learned under his direct supervision (Adegboyega, 1978:40). This form of mentorship was critical for Sakpo's growth in ministry. In 1933, he became the first ordained prophet within TACN (TACN, 1993:35). Despite not having any formal theological education, Pastor Sakpo ascended to significant leadership roles, serving as an international prophet, Apostle, and later as the first vice president and

second LAWNA Territorial Chairman (LTC) of TACN between 1981 and 1993 (Adeleye, 2022).

Similarly, Pastor A. A. Ogundoro followed the apprenticeship mode when he joined TACN's ministry on July 1, 1952. After being interviewed, Ogundoro stayed with senior ministers S. G. Adegboyega and I. G. Sakpo for two weeks to receive in-service ministerial training. He later began his ministry under Pastor J. S. Shonaiya at TAC, Ijebu-Ode. By December 27, 1953, after about a year of service, he was ordained a pastor during the first Ibadan District convention. His career progressed, and in 1983, he became an Area Superintendent. He led the TACN Modakeke Area from 1983 to 2001 and later the Akure Area from 2001 to 2002. Pastor Ogundoro's leadership was marked by significant church growth and development, earning him the reputation of being an exemplary Area Superintendent (Adeleye, 2022).

The apprenticeship mode or in-service training was effective in shaping TACN leaders, despite their lack of formal theological education. It provided practical, on-the-ground training that emphasised spiritual growth, leadership, and direct mentorship. Many of these leaders would go on to shape the direction of the church, contributing significantly to its expansion and development.

### **The Inception of Theological Training in TACN**

The inception of formal theological training within The Apostolic Church Nigeria (TACN) can be traced back to Pastor J. A. Babatope, who was the first among the church's founding fathers to recognise the urgent need for structured ministerial education. Pastor Babatope's vision for a Bible college was aimed at providing adequate theological training for the church's ministerial staff. In 1933, he took the first step toward realising this vision by starting a rigorous Bible class at a semi-formal Bible school. His initial set of students included Pastors Anjorin, Fadahunsi, Odeyemi, and Olatonade. By 1937, more students like Pastors Ogundele, S. O. Akindiya, Oluyomi, and Ataba had joined the programme, with Babatope serving as both principal and teacher (TACN, 2003:19).

Understanding the need for additional resources to formalise the school, Babatope sought assistance from the authorities of The Apostolic Church in Great Britain during the 1937 Penygroes Convention. His efforts were fruitful; he constructed a hall for the Bible school and stocked its library with essential reference materials, such as Bibles and commentaries (TACN, 2003:19). The physical structure of the school was located at Oke-Odo along Omi-Ayo Street, Oke-Ooye, Ilesa, in Osun State, Nigeria, and it became the foundation of formal theological education within TACN.

In response to Babatope's appeal, The Apostolic Church in the United Kingdom established a Bible college in Ilesa. The foundation stone for the college chapel, later known as the Apostolic Teachers' College, was laid on January 1, 1946. The chapel's Gothic architectural style symbolised the strong foundations of formal theological training that TACN sought to build (TACN, 2003:19).

By the 1970s, societal development, technological advancements, and the church's exposure to global trends emphasised the need for ongoing training and retraining of Christian ministers. Congregations became more sophisticated and demanded more from their pastors in terms of biblical knowledge and sermon preparation. Ministers were expected to preach with depth, and formal theological training became a necessity. Brock highlights this shift in ministry dynamics, asserting that theological education had to evolve to meet the increasing expectations of congregants and the complexity of modern ministry (Brock, cited in Ogunewu, 2008:60).

In response, TACN began adopting formal theological training through seminaries and religious studies departments in both Nigeria and abroad (Interview with Alakuko, 2013). To meet this growing demand for theological education, TACN established various institutions, including LAWNA Theological Seminary (LATS) at Ayegbaju in Ilesa, LAWNA Bible College at Irojo Quarters in Ilesa, LATS Jos, TAC Bible College in Uyo, TAC Bible College in Amumara, and TAC Bible College in Bodo, Rivers State. Additionally, in November 2002, TACN expanded its mission to foreign soil by establishing a Bible College in Come, Republic of Benin (TACN, 2003:19).

These institutions played a pivotal role in training the church's leadership. For instance, Pastor Z. A. Alabi, the second national secretary of TACN, was trained both as a theologian and as a church leader in the United States. Similarly, Pastor G. O. Olutola, the current national president of the church and the chairman of LAWNA Territory, received both seminary and secular training (Interview with Ayodele, 2013). Pastor I. G. Fakunle, who once led the students at LAWNA Bible College, rose to the position of LAWNA Administrative Secretary and became a member of TACN's national executive council (Adeleye, 2011:5).

The essence of theological education within TACN is the development of both spiritual and intellectual leadership. Theological seminaries focus on providing ministers with the skills necessary for proper hermeneutical analysis of the Bible. Hermeneutics – the science of interpreting sacred texts – plays a crucial role in ensuring that ministers accurately propagate the gospel. Additionally, theological education helps to produce "men of God" rather than just skilled individuals, with a focus on enhancing church growth. Key subjects taught in seminaries include apologetics, which defends the Christian faith, and evangelism, the core of Christian ministry. Furthermore, theological education emphasises the importance of maintaining Christ-like relationships and leadership skills, which are vital for creating harmony and promoting mutual love within the church (Adeleye, 2011:4).

The seminaries also foster town-gown relationships, promoting social cohesion through education. Theological education helps Christians understand how to maintain harmonious relationships, which in turn creates a peaceful environment conducive to evangelism. Another essential aspect of TACN's theological education is the integration of technological skills. The use of modern tools, such as mobile phones and social media, has become instrumental in evangelising and reaching out to unreached communities (Adeleye, 2011:4). Moreover, according to Ayedogbon (2012), theological education in TACN is designed to raise the standard of preaching and pulpit ministry. In today's competitive age, congregants

look to the pulpit for guidance in critical situations, and if the minister falls short, people may seek alternatives. Seminary education ensures that pastors are well-prepared for such challenges. It is not simply a shortcut to pastoral ordination but a means of fostering humility and unity among the church's officers. The acquisition of knowledge in areas such as hermeneutics, apologetics, evangelism, Christian relations, and technological skills enhances the standard of ministry and leadership in TACN (Interview with Ayedogbon, 2012).

### **TACN's Theological Institutions**

#### **i. The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary, Ilesa**

The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary in Ilesa, Osun State, has a rich history that dates back to 1946 when it was first conceived as a Bible Training Centre (BTC) under the authority of The Apostolic Church (TAC) in Great Britain. The establishment of this Bible School was necessitated by the church's expanding missionary work, which required the services of well-trained evangelists and pastors. The purpose of the training centre was to provide basic ministerial education and develop manpower for new entrants into the Christian ministry. To support the establishment of this institution, TAC in the United Kingdom provided substantial funding, which helped to build the necessary infrastructure for the school. The school adopted the motto, For God and Nigeria, symbolising its dual commitment to religious service and national development (TACN, 1993:43-44).

#### ***Early Developments (1946-1984)***

The first building for the Bible College at Oke-Ooye, Ilesa, was constructed in 1946, serving as a space for both classroom instruction and administrative purposes. Before the formal establishment of the Bible School, Pastor J. A. Babatope had already initiated a semi-formal Bible School where he trained new ministers such as Pastors G. B. Oladele and S. O. Akindiya. In his autobiography, Pastor G. B. Oladele mentioned that he attended the Bible School in 1943, and was taught by prominent leaders including Pastor Babatope, Superintendent Pastor S. G. Elton, and Pastor D. H. McGill (Oladele, n.d.). This earlier version of the Bible School laid the groundwork for the formal Bible Training Institute that would emerge in 1946 (Ogunleye & Lisoye, 1999:12).

In 1969, TACN received a prophetic message instructing the church to unify its various administrative areas, which were previously linked independently to the International Missionary Council in the United Kingdom. This resulted in the amalgamation of TACN's Lagos, Western, and Northern regions into a unified administrative body known as LAWNA (Lagos, Western, and Northern Areas). As part of this unification, the Bible School in Ilesa was brought under LAWNA's management, and its name was changed to TAC LAWNA Bible College (TACN, 1993:44-45).

By April 24, 1984, the seminary moved from its two temporary locations, that is, Apostolic Teachers' College at Oke-Ooye Street and Bolorunduro in Oke-Iro Area, to its permanent

site at Ayegbaju, along Ifewara Road, Ilesa. Pastor I. G. Sakpo coordinated the dedication and opening ceremony of the new buildings. At the time, the seminary's inaugural staff included Pastor D. O. Ajibade (Principal), Pastor B. E. Eni (Vice Principal), and Deaconess V. M. Ajibade (TACN, 1993:46).

***Expansion and Growth (1984-Present)***

The growth and expansion of The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary can be attributed to TACN's increasing missionary efforts. The institution evolved from a Bible School in 1946 to a Bible College, and eventually into a full-fledged theological seminary in October 2001. This transformation reflected the church's commitment to providing a more comprehensive theological education for its ministers.

Several prominent leaders have played significant roles in the seminary's development over the years. One of these was Pastor Dr S. O. Omowole, who served as the Provost during a key period of growth. Under his leadership, the seminary became affiliated with the University of Ibadan in 2004, allowing it to offer more advanced theological education and degree programmes. Pastor Dr I. G. Awotanmi succeeded Omowole, serving as Provost from 2010 to 2015. The seminary continued to grow under subsequent leaders, including Pastor Dr E. O. Olowoyeye and Pastor Professor John Brown, who was succeeded by Pastor G. A. O. Alakuko (TACN, 1993:46).

The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary is currently affiliated with Samuel Adegboyega University in Ogwa, Nigeria. This affiliation has further enhanced the institution's academic standing and expanded its capacity to train future church leaders. The seminary continues to be a key institution within TACN, providing both theological education and ministerial training, and contributing to the growth of the church in Nigeria and beyond.

**ii. The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary, Amumara (TACTSA)**

The Apostolic Church Bible College, now known as The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary, Amumara (TACTSA), was established to provide formal theological education for the ministers of The Apostolic Church in Nigeria. Founded on January 25, 1975, by the Council of TAC Igbo Field, the seminary is located in Amumara, Ezinihitte Mbaise Local Government Area of Imo State. The seminary started with five pioneer staff members: Pastors S. O. Ikpeama (the first principal), S. E. Igwe (vice principal), C. O. Echebiri, Mrs Echebiri, Mrs F. E. Ikpeama, and Mrs R. N. Igwe, along with 22 initial students (Igwe, 2022). The goal of the seminary was to train God-fearing men and women to become effective witnesses for Christ, offering not only theological education but also leadership skills, intellectual growth, moral discipline, and spiritual development.

By 1997, the institution had been upgraded to a full theological seminary, with Pastor S. E. Igwe serving as the rector and supported by 15 staff members. The seminary then began offering a Bachelor of Theology (B. Th.) programme. In the year 2000, TACTSA became affiliated with the Federal University of Uyo, Akwa Ibom State, under the leadership of

Rector Rev. A. A. Akajiaku, Dean of Academic Affairs Rev. C. C. Nwabuko, and Registrar Pastor B. E. Ugbor. This affiliation expanded the academic offerings of the seminary and established it as a centre for theological excellence.

The seminary's reputation as a credible theological institution was further solidified in 1999 when it became a member of the West African Association of Theological Institutions (WAATI). It is currently a correspondent member of the Accrediting Council for Theological Education in Africa (ACTEA). The programmes offered at TACTSA include a Certificate in Theology, Diploma in Theology, Bachelor of Theology, Bachelor in Christian Ministry, Diploma in Religion, and Bachelor of Arts in Religion, making it a diverse and comprehensive centre for theological education in Nigeria.

### iii. **The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary, Bodo, Rivers State**

The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary in Bodo, Rivers State, was established as a response to the growing need for formal ministerial training in the Maritime Field of The Apostolic Church in Nigeria. The seminary was founded in 1978 during the tenure of Superintendent Pastor G. Selby. Before the establishment of this institution, TAC in Rivers State had relied on other denominational institutions for the training of its ministerial staff (TACN, 2017:7).

On September 23, 1978, The Apostolic Bible College was officially opened in Bodo, which served as the headquarters for the institution. The college began with 23 students who enrolled in a three-year Diploma in Theology programme. The pioneer principal, Pastor B. A. Zorasi, alongside Pastors J. B. Leema and E. G. Kogbara, formed the teaching staff during the early years. Between 1982 and 1987, Pastor J. B. Leema served as acting principal while Pastor Zorasi pursued further studies. Upon his return in 1987, Pastor Zorasi resumed his role and continued to serve the institution until 1992, when Pastor E. G. Kogara became acting principal for the following two years (TACN, 2017:7).

In recent years, The Apostolic Bible College has grown significantly, gaining affiliation with Cornerstone University and Seminary of Israel and America, and subsequently being upgraded to a full seminary. It now offers degree programmes including Bachelor of Arts (B.A.), Bachelor of Theology (B. Th.), and Master of Arts (M.A.) in Theology and Religious Education, with courses available at both the main campus in Bodo and its extension campus in Yenagoa.

The seminary expanded its offerings in 1994 by introducing a Bachelor of Theology Degree Programme and a Certificate in Theology. This expansion necessitated the creation of new administrative positions, such as the Deputy Provost, a role filled by Pastor S. B. Baadom, and Registrar, held by Bro. G. A. Obe. The seminary's connection with the Evangelical Christian University of America (ECUA), Louisiana, USA, further solidified its academic credibility. In 1993, ECUA awarded an honorary Doctorate in Divinity (D.D.) to Pastor B. Faara-Vigo, the Rivers Field Superintendent, acknowledging his contributions to theological education.

#### **iv. The Apostolic Church Bible College and Seminary, Calabar**

The Apostolic Church Bible College and Seminary, originally known as the Bible Training Centre, was established in 1989 with approval from the church council in Calabar (Eshu, n.d:259). The creation of the seminary was prompted by the reorganisation following the creation of Akwa Ibom State from Cross River State in 1987. Consequently, TAC Akwa Ibom Field, which had been part of Cross River Field, became an autonomous entity, and properties like the Apostolic Bible College in Nsit Ibom, Uyo, and other TAC assemblies located within Akwa Ibom State's geographical limits were transferred to Akwa Ibom Field. The founding principal of the seminary was Pastor I. B. Ita. The Bible Training Centre initially operated at 101/31 Marian Road, Calabar, before being moved to The Apostolic Church Manse at Queen Duke Street. After some time, it relocated to Ukim Ita for about two and a half years, only to later return to its original location at Marian Road, Calabar, where it remains today.

After the death of Pastor I. B. Ita, the church council appointed Pastor Dr B. E. Duke JP as the new rector of the institution. Under his leadership, the seminary continued to grow, with its admissions policy expanding beyond national boundaries. Pastor Dr D. E. Duke, due to administrative and ministerial challenges, eventually handed over leadership to Chaplain Dr. Obong E. O. Ita, who was appointed as the acting provost of the seminary on August 1, 2010.

#### **v. TAC LAWNA Theological Seminary, Jos, Nigeria**

TAC LAWNA Theological Seminary (LATS) in Jos is one of the key institutions owned by TACN's LAWNA Territory, headquartered in Lagos. The seminary was founded in 1994 and originally operated from its temporary site at Bida Bidi on Zaria Road. In later years, it moved to its permanent site at Gamajigo, off Goodluck Ebele Jonathan Road, in Jos, Plateau State.

The seminary is certified by the Accrediting Council for Theological Education in Africa (ACTEA) and affiliated with the University of Jos. It offers regular, summer, and sandwich programmes leading to three Diplomas, seven Degrees, a Post-Graduate Diploma in Theology (PGDT), and a Master of Arts (M.A.) in Theology and Development Studies.

TAC LAWNA Theological Seminary provides students with a robust theological and practical education, grounded in international development theories and concepts. Students receive training in biblical and theological education, ministerial skills, evangelism, and peacebuilding, preparing them for diverse roles in ministry. The seminary welcomes students from all Christian denominations, without discrimination based on sex, nationality, or physical challenges.

#### **vi. The Apostolic Church LAWNA Territorial Bible College, Irojo Quarters, Ilesa, Osun State**

The Apostolic Church LAWNA Territorial Bible College was established in 2004 in Irojo Quarters, Ilerin Road, Ilesa, Osun State. The creation of the college was driven by the need

to provide theological training for ministers with limited formal education. In 2003, TACN's LAWNA Territory formed a technical committee led by members of The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary, Ilesa, including the Registrar, Pastor A. O. Obisesan, and Pastor C. A. Adeleye. The committee identified a gap in the education of some ministers, who lacked basic theological training or secular education, and recommended the establishment of a Bible College.

This Bible College was aimed at addressing the needs of ministers who were "educated in Jesus but not in English" (A-gbo-Jesu-ma-gboyinbo-ism), helping those who struggled with communication in English or the vernacular to be more effective in Christian ministry. The college provided both theological and vocational training to ensure ministers could serve effectively. Among the programmes offered are adult literacy courses, vocational training, and a Certificate in Theology.

The college's staff has seen multiple leadership changes, with the first principal, Pastor Agunbiade, serving from 2004 to 2008, followed by Pastor Ataba (2008-2012), Pastor Akindele (2013-2016), Pastor Oladele (2016-2023), and Pastor M. O. A. Ayorinde, who took over in 2023. The college is a correspondent member of ACTEA and is affiliated with the Osun State Mass Education Agency for vocational training, as well as the Osun State Ministry of Education for adult literacy.

Over the years, the college has grown, with significant improvements in structural and developmental projects. Today, it remains a vital institution for training new ministers within TACN, ensuring they are equipped for the challenges of ministry in various contexts.

#### **vii. College Biblique Apostolique Du Benin (COBAB)**

On March 3, 2003, College Biblique Apostolique Du Benin (COBAB), also known as The Apostolic Church Bible College, Republic of Benin, was established by the LAWNA Territory of The Apostolic Church Nigeria (TACN). The creation of this Bible College marked a significant step in expanding TACN's theological education and missionary work beyond Nigeria, into the neighbouring country of Benin.

The college was officially inaugurated with Pastor E. O. Akinwale serving as the pioneer principal. He was supported by six members of the academic staff and the inaugural class of 28 students. The primary objective of COBAB was to provide theological education and training to support effective Christian ministry in the Republic of Benin. COBAB's curriculum emphasised the development of biblical knowledge, leadership skills, and practical ministry training, all aimed at equipping future church leaders.

On December 10, 2005, the first group of students graduated from COBAB during a national convention held in Porto-Novo. The establishment and success of the Bible College contributed significantly to the spread of Christianity in the Republic of Benin by producing well-trained ministers capable of serving their communities with a deep understanding of the Bible and effective ministerial skills.

Over time, COBAB grew to include three campuses located in Come, Porto-Novo, and Natitengou. These campuses expanded the reach of TACN's theological education and helped nurture future generations of church leaders across the country. The institution's growth and influence have been pivotal in supporting the church's mission in Benin, fostering a strong foundation for Christian leadership in the region (Akinwale, Interview Respondent, 10 April 2022).

Pastor E. O. Akinwale, as the pioneer principal, played a central role in the establishment and early development of COBAB, ensuring that the institution adhered to its mission of producing capable and spiritually grounded ministers. The Bible College continues to be an essential part of TACN's global outreach, promoting Christian education and expanding the church's influence in West Africa.

### **Evaluating the Contributions of TACN's Theological Institutions: Their Role in Shaping Doctrinal Teaching and Ministerial Effectiveness**

TACN has established numerous theological institutions over the years, which have played a critical role in shaping the church's doctrinal teachings and enhancing ministerial effectiveness. These institutions spread across Nigeria and neighbouring countries, contribute to the church's mission of equipping ministers with theological knowledge, practical skills, and spiritual maturity. Their influence is reflected in the doctrinal consistency, growth of the church, and the overall effectiveness of TACN's ministry.

#### **i. Shaping Doctrinal Teaching**

TACN's theological institutions have maintained the church's doctrinal purity. As a Pentecostal denomination, TACN emphasises the centrality of biblical authority, the work of the Holy Spirit, divine healing, and the anticipation of Christ's imminent return. Through structured theological education, these institutions ensure that ministers are well-grounded in these core beliefs and are capable of transmitting them effectively to their congregations.

For instance, the establishment of The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary (LATS) in Ilesa and Jos ensured that ministers received formal training in biblical interpretation, systematic theology, and Pentecostal distinctives. This doctrinal training helps to counter the misinterpretations or dilution of TACN's theological stance. LATS and other seminaries have shaped the church's emphasis on charismatic gifts, aligning ministers with the church's teaching on spiritual manifestations and biblical truths (TACN, 1993:44-46).

Similarly, The Apostolic Church Bible College and Seminary in Calabar has contributed to doctrinal clarity, particularly in southeastern Nigeria. The seminary's focus on robust biblical training and apologetics ensures that ministers are well-equipped to defend the faith and articulate TACN's doctrinal positions in a rapidly changing religious landscape. This has helped to maintain doctrinal consistency across the diverse regions of Nigeria and beyond.

## ii. Enhancing Ministerial Effectiveness

TACN's theological institutions have significantly improved the ministerial effectiveness of its clergy. The shift from informal training through the apprenticeship model to more formal theological education has enabled ministers to handle the increasingly complex demands of ministry in contemporary society. Ministers trained at TACN's institutions are now better equipped with practical skills in preaching, pastoral care, leadership, and church administration.

The College Biblique Apostolique Du Benin (COBAB), for example, has trained ministers who are not only theologically proficient but also capable of engaging in cross-cultural ministry. With campuses in Come, Porto-Novo, and Natitengou, COBAB plays a vital role in equipping ministers to engage with local communities and navigate cultural challenges while maintaining doctrinal integrity (Akinwole, Interview Respondent, 2022). This has allowed TACN to expand its reach into Benin, contributing to the growth of Christianity in the region.

The Apostolic Church Bible College in Bodo, Rivers State, also enhances ministerial effectiveness through its diverse programmes. The introduction of diploma and degree programmes in theology, along with leadership training, has enabled ministers to grow both spiritually and intellectually. Ministers trained at Bodo are better able to address the needs of their congregations, lead effectively, and engage in evangelistic outreach.

Moreover, TACTSA (The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary, Amumara) provides a comprehensive curriculum that covers areas such as homiletics, Christian leadership, and moral discipline. These programmes enhance the capacity of ministers to lead their congregations and contribute meaningfully to their spiritual development. The seminary's affiliation with the University of Uyo, Akwa Ibom State, further enhances the academic rigour of its programmes, ensuring that ministers are well-rounded in their approach to ministry (Igwe, 2022).

In addition, LAWNA Theological Seminary in Jos incorporates international development concepts into its curriculum, equipping ministers with practical skills to address social issues such as peacebuilding, interfaith dialogue, and community development. This approach enhances the ministers' ability to engage with broader societal issues, making them more effective in their ministerial roles.

## iii. Producing Leaders for Church Growth

Theological institutions under TACN have also played a key role in producing leaders who contribute to the growth and expansion of the church. By providing formal leadership training, these institutions ensure that ministers are not only capable of theological teaching but are also equipped to manage the operational and administrative aspects of the church.

Leaders trained at The Apostolic Church LAWNA Bible College, Irojo Quarters, Ilesha, have significantly contributed to the church's growth in Nigeria by bridging the gap for ministers

with limited formal education. The Bible College focuses on adult literacy and vocational training in addition to theological education, thus preparing ministers to serve in diverse contexts. This inclusivity ensures that even ministers with educational deficiencies are equipped for effective ministry, contributing to the church's expansion across different social strata.

Moreover, many of TACN's prominent leaders have received their education from these institutions. For instance, the national president of TACN, Pastor G. O. Olutola, and other key figures in the church's leadership structure, were trained at theological seminaries, ensuring that TACN's leadership reflects the doctrinal and ministerial standards of the church (Interview with Ayodele, 2013). These leaders have played significant roles in driving the church's mission and ensuring its sustainability.

### **Challenges Faced by TACN in Sustaining its Theological Education Programmes**

Despite the significant contributions of The Apostolic Church Nigeria (TACN) in theological education, the church faces numerous challenges in sustaining its theological education programmes. These challenges impact the effectiveness and reach of its theological institutions, limiting their potential to fully serve the church's mission of producing well-rounded, doctrinally sound, and spiritually empowered ministers.

#### **i. Funding Limitations**

One of the most pressing challenges facing TACN's theological institutions is insufficient funding. The establishment and maintenance of seminaries, Bible colleges, and other educational institutions require substantial financial investment. Many of TACN's theological institutions operate on limited budgets, which restricts their ability to attract qualified faculty, update infrastructure, and provide necessary resources like libraries, research materials, and modern technology.

The shortage of funds also affects the ability to offer scholarships or financial aid to deserving students, reducing access to theological education for individuals from lower-income backgrounds. For instance, schools like the Apostolic Church Bible College and Seminary in Calabar and the LAWNA Territorial Bible College in Ilesa have experienced resource constraints that hinder their growth and development. To enhance the effectiveness of these theological institutions, TACN must invest in modernising its infrastructure, including digital resources and distance learning platforms, to reach more students across different regions.

#### **ii. Balancing Pentecostal Charisma with Formal Education**

Another significant challenge is the tension between Pentecostal charisma and formal theological education. Within TACN, there is a strong emphasis on the direct work of the Holy Spirit, spiritual gifts, and charismatic expressions of faith. This has led to scepticism among some church members and leaders about the necessity of formal theological education.

Some fear that academic training might stifle spiritual spontaneity or foster intellectual pride, detracting from the reliance on the Holy Spirit that characterises Pentecostal ministry. This aversion to formal education has persisted in parts of the church, making it difficult to achieve universal acceptance of theological seminaries, particularly in rural areas where charismatic expressions are more prominent.

### **iii. Cultural and Linguistic Barriers**

The diversity of languages and cultures within Nigeria presents another challenge for TACN's theological institutions. While English is the official language of instruction in many of these seminaries, a significant number of students come from regions where English is not their primary language. This creates a barrier to effective learning, as students may struggle to fully grasp the curriculum.

Additionally, theological education often needs to be contextualised to address specific cultural and religious challenges faced in different regions. For example, ministers serving in the predominantly Muslim northern regions of Nigeria face different social and religious challenges than those serving in the Christian-dominated southern regions. Seminaries may not always have the resources or faculty to provide localised or contextual theological education that meets the needs of these diverse regions.

### **iv. Resource and Infrastructure Deficiencies**

Many of TACN's theological institutions lack access to modern resources and infrastructure. Digital libraries, online learning platforms, and up-to-date theological texts are often unavailable, which limits the ability of students and faculty to engage with contemporary theological debates and scholarship. In today's information-driven world, the absence of modern technological infrastructure makes it difficult for these institutions to stay current with global developments in theology and ministry.

The global shift toward digital education, especially during the COVID-19 pandemic, has further highlighted the need for technological advancements. For example, TACTSA and COBAB have limited access to online learning resources, which could expand the reach of theological education to remote areas and non-traditional students.

### **v. Recruitment and Retention of Qualified Faculty**

TACN's theological institutions also face difficulties in recruiting and retaining qualified faculty. Many seminaries rely on part-time or visiting lecturers, which affects the consistency and quality of education provided. Limited funding prevents these institutions from offering competitive salaries and benefits, which makes it harder to attract and retain top-tier theologians and academics.

The lack of qualified faculty limits the range of subjects that can be offered and affects the overall academic rigour of the programmes. Institutions such as TAC LAWNA Theological

Seminary in Jos and The Apostolic Church Bible College in Bodo, Rivers State may struggle to offer specialised courses or advanced theological programmes due to faculty shortages.

**vi. Geopolitical and Security Challenges**

Theological education in Nigeria is also impacted by the country's geopolitical and security challenges. In regions affected by religious or political unrest, such as the northern parts of Nigeria, students and faculty face disruptions to their studies. Institutions in these areas must also contend with the risk of violence, attacks, or instability, which can lead to closures, interruptions, and a decline in student enrolment.

For example, TAC LAWNA Theological Seminary in Jos, located in a region that has experienced periodic inter-religious violence, faces significant challenges in maintaining a stable learning environment. Students in these areas are often forced to navigate not only academic challenges but also safety concerns.

**vii. Perception of Theological Education**

There is also a broader challenge regarding the perception of theological education within the Pentecostal tradition. Many within TACN view theological education primarily as a requirement for pastoral ordination, rather than as a lifelong pursuit of spiritual and intellectual growth. As a result, some ministers may seek out theological training only as a means to advance their careers rather than to deepen their understanding of the faith. This utilitarian approach undermines the true purpose of theological education, which is to equip ministers for both spiritual and intellectual leadership.

**viii. Tension between the charismatic, Spirit-led Traditions of the Church and the Emphasis on Formal Theological Training**

One challenge is the tension between the charismatic, Spirit-led traditions of the church and the emphasis on formal theological training. Some within TACN continue to view theological education with suspicion, believing that it can stifle the spontaneous work of the Holy Spirit in ministry. Moreover, fostering a balance between Spirit-led ministry and formal education will help dispel concerns about the role of theology in Pentecostal ministry. A more integrated approach that emphasises the complementary nature of spiritual empowerment and theological training will ensure that TACN continues to produce ministers who are both doctrinally sound and spiritually dynamic.

**Suggested Strategies for Enhancing Effectiveness**

To overcome these challenges and enhance the effectiveness of TACN's theological education programmes, the following strategies could be adopted:

**i. Comprehensive Funding Strategies**

TACN should develop comprehensive funding strategies to address the financial constraints faced by its theological institutions. This could include establishing endowment

funds, encouraging congregations to contribute through special offerings, and seeking partnerships with international organisations that support theological education in Africa. These funds can be used to improve infrastructure, provide scholarships, and hire qualified faculty.

**ii. Integrating Pentecostal Spirituality with Formal Education**

TACN's seminaries can emphasise the complementary nature of Pentecostal spirituality and formal theological education by integrating courses on spiritual formation, charismatic gifts, and Pentecostal practices into the curriculum. This would help dispel concerns that theological education undermines spiritual empowerment while affirming the value of both Spirit-led ministry and academic rigour.

**iii. Contextualising Theological Education**

Theological education in TACN must be tailored to meet the needs of different cultural and linguistic contexts. This can be achieved by offering localised theological programmes in indigenous languages and focusing on the specific cultural and religious issues faced in various regions. Partnering with local theological institutions across Nigeria could also help share resources and expertise to develop Contextualised education.

**iv. Investing in Technological Infrastructure**

To modernise TACN's theological education, investments must be made in digital infrastructure, such as online learning platforms and digital libraries. This would improve access to contemporary theological resources and make education more accessible to students in remote areas. Offering online and hybrid learning models would expand the reach of theological education and allow for greater flexibility in course delivery.

**v. Faculty Development and Retention**

Efforts must be made to attract and retain qualified faculty by offering competitive salaries, benefits, and opportunities for professional development. TACN should also establish faculty exchange programmes with other theological institutions, both in Nigeria and internationally, to encourage collaboration and ensure continuous academic improvement.

**vi. Addressing Security Concerns**

TACN should establish contingency plans to protect students and faculty in regions facing geopolitical and security challenges. This could include partnering with local authorities to ensure campus security, offering online alternatives for students in affected areas, and setting up emergency response systems to minimise disruptions to academic programmes.

### Conclusion

The Apostolic Church Nigeria (TACN) has made notable progress in establishing and sustaining theological education, which has been pivotal in shaping the church's doctrinal consistency and ministerial effectiveness. From its initial scepticism toward formal theological training to the establishment of key institutions like The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary in Amumara, The Apostolic Church Bible College and Seminary in Calabar, and The Apostolic Church LAWNA Theological Seminary in Jos, TACN has demonstrated an increasing commitment to equipping its leaders with the necessary intellectual and spiritual tools for ministry. These institutions have played a crucial role in maintaining doctrinal fidelity while fostering leadership skills, contributing to the church's expansion in Nigeria and neighbouring regions. By offering structured platforms for theological and pastoral training, they ensure ministers are well-prepared for the contemporary ministry's spiritual and practical challenges.

However, as this study has shown, TACN faces significant challenges sustaining these theological education programmes. Limited financial resources, cultural resistance to formal education, and the difficulty of balancing Pentecostal spirituality with academic rigour hinder the church's ability to fully capitalise on its educational infrastructure. To address these challenges, TACN must make strategic investments in its institutions, focusing on improving infrastructure, integrating technological advancements, and enhancing faculty development. Furthermore, there is a need to contextualise theological education in a way that reflects the church's unique Pentecostal identity while meeting the evolving needs of society.

Financial constraints of TACN's theological institutions, as in the analysis, suggest an urgent need for diversified funding sources, including partnerships with global theological organisations and local church-based funding initiatives. Cultural resistance, particularly the perception that academic training undermines spiritual empowerment, can be mitigated by integrating spiritual formation into the curriculum and aligning it with the charismatic elements that define Pentecostal practice. Additionally, improving faculty development by providing opportunities for continuous education and cross-institutional collaboration can further strengthen the quality of instruction.

This study identifies several areas for future research. First, a deeper exploration of the specific contributions of individual seminaries, such as College Biblique Apostolique Du Benin (COBAB) and The Apostolic Church Bible College in Bodo, could provide insights into how these institutions uniquely shape leadership within TACN. Additionally, examining the experiences of graduates from these theological institutions would offer a clearer picture of how academic training translates into ministerial effectiveness on the ground. Finally, more research is needed on the role of women in TACN's theological education programmes, which remains an underexplored area despite the growing presence of women in Pentecostal leadership roles.

The findings from this study are significant not only for TACN but also for other Pentecostal movements in Nigeria and globally. The challenges faced by TACN, such as the tension

between experiential spirituality and academic training, are common to many Pentecostal denominations. TACN's efforts to balance these two aspects can serve as a model for other churches looking to integrate formal theological education with their charismatic traditions. Furthermore, the church's ability to navigate financial and cultural challenges while advancing its theological education programmes offers valuable lessons for other denominations facing similar issues.

## References

- Adegboyega, S.G. (1978). *Short history of The Apostolic Church in Nigeria*. Ibadan: Rosprint.
- Adeleye, C.A. (2011). *Basics of theological education and church growth in Nigeria*. A Lecture Delivered During the Inauguration of Christian Relations Studies at TACN, Ado-Ekiti, Ekiti State on 6 June 2011.
- Adeleye, C.A. (2022). *Leadership dynamics and the growth of The Apostolic Church Nigeria*. PhD thesis at Faculty of Arts, Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife.
- Akanbi, S.O., & Beyers, J. (2017). The church as a catalyst for transformation in the society. *HTS TheologiesStudies/Theological Studies*, 73(4): a4635.
- Akindele, S.K. (2017). *Interview Respondent*, Principal, The Apostolic Church LAWNA Territorial Bible College, Irojo Quarters, Ilerin Road, Ilesa, Osun State, Nigeria on June 6.
- Alakuko, G.O.A. (2013). *Interview Respondent*, Lecturer/Pastor, LATS, Ilesa on August 27.
- Alvarez, M. (2000). Distinctives of Pentecostal education. *Asian Journal of Pentecostal Studies*, 3(2): 281-293.
- Anderson, A. (2004). *An introduction to Pentecostalism: Global Charismatic Christianity*. Cambridge University Press.
- Aryeh, D.N.A. (2018). Academic versus spiritual: Theological education and the anointing of the holy spirit in contemporary prophetic ministries in Ghana. *Journal of Contemporary Ministry*, 4: 61-77.
- Asamoah-Gyadu, J. (2005). *African Charismatics: Current developments within independent indigenous Pentecostalism in Ghana*. Leiden: Brill.
- Awojobi, P.O. (2020). The impacts of Pentecostal churches on the growth of Christianity in Nigeria. *Sapientia Global Journal of Arts, Humanities and Development Studies (SGOJAHDS)*, 3(3): 1-10.
- Awotanmi, I.G. (2012). *Interview Respondent*, Provost, LATS, Ilesa on April 12.
- Ayedogbon, J.K. (2012). *Interview Respondent*, Lecturer/Pastor, LATS, Ilesa on 27 Aug. 2012.
- Ayodele, E.A. (2013). *Interview Respondent*, Librarian, LATS, Ilesa on Sept., 13
- Banda, C. (2019). Managing an elusive force? The Holy Spirit and the anointed articles of Pentecostal prophets in traditional religious Africa. *Verbum et Ecclesia*, 40(1): a2025. <https://doi.org/10.4102/ve.v40i1.2025>
- Brief Biography of Late Pastor Abel Adeoye Ogundoro, TAC Akure Area, LAWNA, Nigeria, Order of Funeral Service held in honour of Pastor Abel Adeoye Ogundoro on 20-21 December 2001, 14-15. Between 1991 and 2000, one of the researchers worked closely with Pastor A. A. Ogundoro during his tenure of leadership of TACN, Modakeke Area.
- Cartledge, M.J., & Swoboda, A.J. (2016). *Scripting Pentecost: A study of Pentecostals, worship, and liturgy*. London: Routledge.
- Castelo, D. (2015). *Pneumatology: A guide for the perplexed*. Bloomsbury.
- Cox, H. (1995). *Fire from Heaven: The rise of Pentecostal spirituality and the reshaping of religion in the twenty-first century*. Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley.
- Dada, A.O. (2007). Theological education in the Old Testament and the contemporary state of theological education in Nigeria. *Orita: IJRS*, xxxix(1): 41-55.

- Dayton, D. (1987). *The theological roots of Pentecostalism*. Grand Rapids, MI: Zondervan.
- de Beer, S. (2020). Theological education and African cities: An imperative for action. *Missionalia*, 48(3): 231-256. <https://dx.doi.org/10.7832/48-3-418>
- Deininger, M. (2013). *Global Pentecostalism: An inquiry into the cultural dimensions of globalization*. Hamburg: Anchor Academic.
- Esuh, A.O. (nd). *Brief history: The advent of The Apostolic Church in Nigeria*.
- Fafunwa, A.B. (1974). *History of education in Nigeria*. NPS Educational Publishers.
- Feller, J., & Lombaard, C. (2018). Spiritual formation towards Pentecostal leadership as discipleship. *Koers*, 83(1): 1-12. <https://dx.doi.org/10.19108/koers.83.1.2254>
- Frestadius, S. (2021). Pentecostal theological education: Mapping the historical landscape and reflecting on a theological future. *PentecoStudies*, 20(1): 56-77. <https://doi.org/10.1558/pent.18624>
- Gathogo, J.M. (2022). The shifting landscape of African-Pentecostalism in Kenya. *Theologia Viatorum*, 46(1): a121. <https://doi.org/10.4102/tv.v46i1.121>
- Igwe, S.E. (2022). *Interview Respondent*, President TACN on Aug., 20
- Kalu, O. (2008). *African Pentecostalism: An introduction*. Oxford University Press.
- Kgatle, M.S. (2024). Leadership by the Spirit in Pentecostalism: A transformational pneumatocracy approach. *Acta Theologica*, 44(1): 121-137.
- Kgatle, M.S. (2018). Integrating African Pentecostalism into the theological education of South African Universities: An urgent task. *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies*, 74(3): 5130.
- Knoetze, J.J. (2022). Theological education, spiritual formation and leadership development in Africa: What does God have to do with it? *HTS Teologiese Studies/Theological Studies*, 78(4): a7521.
- LATS Church Record (2017), collected from LATS, Jos, 23 November, 2016.
- Miller, D.E. (2013). Pentecostalism as a global phenomenon. In D.E. Miller, K.H. Sargeant & R. Flory (eds.), *Spirit and power: The growth and global impact of Pentecostalism*. New York, online edn, Oxford Academic. <https://doi.org/10.1093/acprof:oso/9780199920570.003.0015>
- Nel, M. (2018). Pentecostal ecumenical impulses: Past and present challenges. *In die Skriflig*, 52(1): 1-8. <https://dx.doi.org/10.4102/ids.v52i1.2330>
- Nguyen, N.V. (2008). Leadership skills development in theological seminary: crucial factors in creating effective local church leadership. *Theses and Dissertations*. 2. <https://digitalcommons.pepperdine.edu/etd/2>
- O'Brien, R.J. (2019). Models of spiritual leadership: Strategies for bridging the gap between policy and ethics. *Dissertations*. 31. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.31979/etd.fesh-3csg>
- Ogunewu, L. (2008). Charismatic movements and theological education: Past, present and future. *Ogbomoso Journal of Theology OJOT*, 13(2): 58-83.
- Ogunleye, M., & Lisoye, L. (1999). *The making of a minister: A biography of Pastor S. O. Akindiya*. Abeokuta: TAC.
- Okon, E.E. (2001). Brief outline of The Apostolic Church in the Cross River State Field, Nigeria" in *Souvenir, The Apostolic Church Nigeria, 2<sup>nd</sup> National Convention; 70<sup>th</sup> Birthday Anniversary; Brief History of TAC in Nigeria*, Lagos: Alsun.
- Oladele, G.B. *Brief Autobiography of Pastor G. B. Oladele* (unpublished).
- Olutola, G.O. (2015). *Interview Respondent*, President, TACN on March 8.
- Order of proceedings of the 39<sup>th</sup> Convocation of The Apostolic Church Theological Seminary, Amumara (TACTSA) held on Saturday, 12 Nov., 2016.
- Ott, B. (2001). Mission oriented theological education: Moving beyond traditional models of theological education. *Transformation*, 18(2): 74-86. <http://www.jstor.org/stable/43053931>
- Quampah, D., & Naidoo, M. (2000). Pursuing the ideal of integration in Pentecostal theological education: A case study of Pentecost theological seminary, Ghana. *Acta Theologica*, 40(2): 300-320. DOI: <http://dx.doi.org/10.18820/23099089/actat.v40i2.16>